

Subdued presence: India women's team captain Salima Tete failed to rise to the occasion. GETTY IMAGES

barely tried. With set-pieces playing such a decisive role in modern hockey, this shortcoming is critical.

Two players who did enhance their reputations were Manpreet Singh and Hardik Singh. Manpreet, the second Indian to earn 400 international caps, continued to set high standards of fitness and work rate. Hardik, meanwhile, remains the team's heartbeat. Together, they played key roles in salvaging pride — if not points — during a grim tour.

If one were to play Devil's Advocate, the men endured a similarly dismal Pro League campaign in 2023–24 — five wins and six draws en route to a seventh-place finish — yet bounced back to retain their Olympic bronze in Paris. In that sense, this latest failure could be well-timed, giving Fulton space to rethink strategies and personnel ahead of a crucial year. The Asia Cup, at home in two months, offers India its best chance to qualify for the World Cup. If they make it, Fulton and his squad will have a year to fine-tune plans — with the Asian Games also looming shortly after.

Back to the drawing board

For the women, the road ahead is murkier. With just two wins from 16 matches and a paltry 10 points, the team finds itself on a worrying downward spiral — with few signs of an imminent turnaround.

Having missed out on the Paris Olympics, India was expected to rebuild. While the India leg of the Pro League hinted at promise, the European leg quickly crushed such optimism. Last year's Asian Champions Trophy triumph, too, now feels hollow — most opponents, including China, Japan and Korea had fielded inexperienced squads.

India's tour of Australia yielded just one win in five games. And despite coach Harendra Singh's emphasis on fitness, the team could not match higher-ranked sides across London, Antwerp, and Berlin the way it had in Bhubaneswar.

Penalty corner defence remained



India's Achilles heel. Belgium, Argentina, Australia, China — all feasted on a fragile backline. A 3-0 loss to China in the penultimate match — with two PC goals — effectively sealed its fate. Even winning the final game wouldn't have helped a -20 goal difference.

India looked second-best in every area. Rarely did it threaten the opposition, barring brief spells in a few matches. The build-up play was impatient, attacks too individualistic, the defence unsettled, and the midfield unable to link or create alternatives. There was little imagination or tactical flexibility, and the experienced players failed to lead.

Neha, Lalremsiami, Navneet Kaur, and Salima Tete didn't rise to the occasion. The youngsters — Sakshi Rana, Rutuja Pisal, Jyoti Singh — could not fill the void. Inconsistency, which was brushed off during the India leg, returned to haunt the team under pressure. Deepika and Manisha Chauhan, brought in for PC duties, looked ineffective. Even Savita Punia, one of the more reliable players, was left stranded by a porous defence.

Ahead of a pivotal year, relegation is a hammer blow. Unlike the men, the women do not dominate Asia. The Asia Cup will be fiercely contested, and if that fails, India will be left relying on the World Cup qualifiers. It'll also miss the Pro

League's exposure — 16 top-tier games they can no longer count on.

Last year, India had similarly poor numbers, with the same number of wins but two fewer points — but were saved by an even weaker USA, which had already booked its Paris spot. This time, there's no safety net. Not winning the Asian Games, missing Paris, and now two consecutive seasons of poor returns — these are not signs of a team in transition. They are signs of a team in trouble. The decline from that fourth-place finish at the Tokyo Olympics is not recent — and it's certainly not just about who's in charge.



MEN

Matches Played: 16

Wins: 6

Draws: 0

Losses: 10

Goals Scored: 34

Goals Conceded: 38

WOMEN

Matches Played: 16

Wins: 2

Draws: 3

Losses: 11

Goals Scored: 22

Goals Conceded: 43